CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 03

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



RETAIL

Keep the shutters up.

Payment outages, cyber attacks, abuse on the shop floor, lockdowns and warm freezers. How to keep stores trading and colleagues safe when it goes wrong at peak.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

__TOC__

FOREWORD

Retail crises rarely start at head office. They start at a till, a freezer or a shop door.

In April 2025 a cyber attack forced Marks and Spencer in the UK to pause online orders for 46 days, and the retailer estimated the hit to operating profit at around £300m before mitigation.[1,2] In October 2026 an incident at Ahold Delhaize took online grocery services offline in the Benelux and the US; the group expects fourth-quarter sales to be €200m to €250m lower.[3]

The same month, attackers switched supermarket refrigeration into defrost from the internet. France's CERT-FR reported numerous compromised controllers, and US agencies including CISA and the FBI later warned of ongoing attacks on refrigeration and cold chain monitoring systems.[4,5] On the shop floor, the British Retail Consortium counts more than 1,600 incidents of violence and abuse against UK retail staff every day.[6]

This playbook is for the people who have to hold it all together: resilience, security, store operations, IT and communications leaders, wherever their stores trade. It sets out how a store, its region and head office work as one team on the busiest day of the year, who decides what, what to have ready before each peak and the messages to send in the first hour. It ends with a practical toolkit you can use straight away. The companion intelligence report sets out the evidence in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Stores, regions and head office must run one incident, not three.

01 · THE OPERATIONAL CHALLENGE

- Head office decisions, such as switching systems off, land on stores within minutes, often before anyone has told them.
- Peaks such as Black Friday, White Friday, Christmas and the end of Ramadan multiply queues, staffing gaps and pressure.
- Store managers see problems first but often lack a fast way to raise them and know they have landed.

02 · INCIDENTS AND RISKS TO PREPARE FOR

- Card payment or till outages across many stores or online, from a provider fault or an attack.
- Cyber attacks that force systems offline and can start 72-hour breach notification clocks in several jurisdictions.
- Violence and abuse against colleagues, and incidents that need evacuation, invacuation or lockdown.
- Refrigeration and cold-chain failures, including controllers tampered with remotely, that put food safety at risk.

03 · KEY RECOMMENDATIONS

- Use one severity ladder and one escalation workflow across store, region and head office.
- Agree decision rights now: who closes a store, who switches to cash, who speaks to the media.
- Pre-approve messages for stores, colleagues, customers, regulators, suppliers and media, each with a next update time.
- Map breach notification deadlines, card acquirer contacts and food temperature limits for every country you trade in.
- Rehearse a payment outage, a lockdown and a cold-chain incident with stores before every peak.

04 · WHAT EFFECTIVE COORDINATION LOOKS LIKE

- Every store acknowledges within minutes, and silent stores are chased by their regional manager.
- Store managers act on safety at once; head office hears straight after.
- One log holds every decision, owner and reason, from first report to stand down.
- A store-by-store view shows who is trading, cash only, closed or in need of help.

05 · HOW CRISES CONTROL SUPPORTS THE RESPONSE

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end.

Crises Control is an Operational Incident Coordination Platform. Ping reaches store and regional managers on several channels, and acknowledgements show which stores have heard.

Plans you build turn the cash procedure, lockdown and cold-chain checks into owned tasks, with escalation on no response under rules you configure.

INTRODUCTION

Three things keep a store trading on a bad day.

Retail incidents move fast and land on the shop floor first. The retailers that cope best are not the ones with the thickest manuals. They are the ones where stores, regions and head office already know who decides, how they talk and what each store does without being asked.

One incident, one team

A store manager, a regional manager and the head office incident lead share the same severity scale, the same facts and the same clock. Nobody waits for a meeting to start.

Fast, two-way messages

Head office can reach every store, and every store can reach head office, in minutes, with a record of who has read what and who has not.

People before stock

Every procedure starts with colleague and customer safety, from a queue that turns hostile to a lockdown call or a freezer that cannot be trusted.

Sending an alert to every store is the easy part. Running the incident end to end is where most retailers struggle.

Most retailers can send alerts. Far fewer can take an incident from the first report at a till, through decisions, tasks and customer messages, to stand down and a record that stands up to scrutiny. That gap is where trading, colleagues and trust are lost.

PART 01

Ready for peak.

Decide now how stores, regions and head office work together, what the law expects where you trade and who decides what.

01 Store and head office as one team

02 Six threats, first moves

03 Breach notification by region

04 Cold-chain rules by region

05 Who decides what

READY FOR PEAK

One incident, two worlds: the store and head office

> **Every head office decision has a store consequence, and someone must own telling stores about it.**

A retail incident is lived in two places at once. At head office, it is a dashboard turning red, a bridge call and a decision about which systems to switch off. In the store, it is a queue that will not move, a customer who wants to know why and a manager who has heard nothing.

The 2025 attacks on UK retailers showed how quickly the two worlds connect. Marks and Spencer first disclosed a cyber incident after problems with contactless payments and click and collect over the Easter weekend, and stopped taking online orders three days later.[2]

The decisions that protect the business at head office are often the ones that hurt stores most. Taking systems offline can stop an attacker. It can also stop stock files, price updates, loyalty scanners and delivery slots. When Ahold Delhaize took systems offline in October 2026, it said disruption to online capabilities and to Benelux supply chain operations would weigh on fourth-quarter sales.[3]

So the first rule of retail incident management is that every head office decision has a store consequence, and someone must own telling stores about it. The second is that information must flow upwards as well as down. Store managers see the effects first: the first declined card, the first fridge alarm, the first group of shoplifters who turn aggressive. They need a fast, simple way to raise it and to know it has landed.

That means one severity scale that stores, regions and head office all use, one place where the facts live, scheduled updates even when there is nothing new, and acknowledgement from every store so you know who has not heard. It also means trusting store managers with clear authority to act on safety without waiting for permission: to close a door, stop a queue or take stock off sale.

None of this needs to be built during an incident. It needs to be agreed, written down and rehearsed before the busiest weeks of the year, whichever calendar your stores trade to.

SIX THREATS

Six retail threats and the first moves that matter

What each side does in the first five minutes, without waiting to be told.

THREAT	FIRST STORE ACTION	FIRST HEAD OFFICE ACTION
Till or payment outage	Switch to the cash and offline procedure. Stop restarting terminals. Tell customers what works.	Confirm scope. Send one instruction to all stores with the next update time.
Cyber attack on core systems	Trade on what still works. Report anything odd. Do not reset devices unless told.	Contain, keep evidence, decide what to switch off and tell stores what each shutdown means.[3]
Violence or abuse	Make safe, call emergency services if anyone is in danger, do not pursue. Colleague first.	Check it is logged and reported, support the manager, make the next shifts safe.
Fire, threat or attack nearby	Evacuate, invacuate or lock down as briefed. Account for colleagues.	Alert nearby stores, convene the incident group, own customer and media lines.
Cold-chain failure	Probe food by hand, take unsafe stock off sale, do not just reset the controller.[4,5]	Call the contractor, find other sites with the same controllers, take them offline.
Rogue message to customers	Expect questions. Use the approved line and do not guess.	Lock the channel used, then tell customers plainly what to ignore.

REGIONAL NOTES · BREACH NOTIFICATION

After a cyber attack: who you must tell, and how fast

Retail attacks often expose customer or loyalty data and card payments. Deadlines start when you become aware of a breach, so the decision log must record that moment.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED KINGDOM

UK GDPR Article 33: notify the regulator without undue delay and, where feasible, within 72 hours of becoming aware of a personal data breach, unless it is unlikely to result in a risk to people. From 30 September 2026 the text names the Information Commission, which took over from the ICO.[7]

IN PRACTICE Record the time of awareness and your risk assessment in the Incident decision log. If you notify late, give reasons.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED STATES

All states, the District of Columbia, Puerto Rico and the Virgin Islands have breach notification laws; triggers and deadlines vary by state.[8] For card data, PCI DSS Requirement 12.10.1 (an industry standard, applied through your acquirer) requires an incident response plan that covers notifying payment brands and acquirers.[9]

IN PRACTICE Map which states your customers live in. Keep acquirer and payment brand contacts in the plan, wherever you trade.

REGIONAL NOTE · EUROPEAN UNION

GDPR Article 33: notify the competent supervisory authority without undue delay and, where feasible, within 72 hours. Article 34: tell affected people without undue delay where the breach is likely to result in a high risk to them.[10]

IN PRACTICE Know your lead supervisory authority in advance if you trade in several member states.

REGIONAL NOTE · MIDDLE EAST

UAE: Federal Decree-Law No. 45 of 2021 requires controllers to report breaches to the UAE Data Office; timing is left to Executive Regulations, which legal summaries report as not yet published. DIFC and ADGM have their own laws.[11] **Saudi Arabia:** the PDPL is fully enforceable from 14 September 2024; notify SDAIA within 72 hours where a breach is likely to cause harm. A draft amendment would drop that harm test (proposed).[12]

IN PRACTICE Check which law applies to each store, including free zone sites, and name who files the notice.

A summary for orientation, not legal advice. Requirements depend on sector, size, licence and jurisdiction, and change over time. Confirm the current text with your legal and compliance teams.

REGIONAL NOTES · COLD CHAIN

The temperature rules behind the fridge

When a controller cannot be trusted, the question is simple: can you show the food stayed within the limit that applies where you trade? If not, it comes off sale.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED KINGDOM

Chilled food must legally be kept at 8°C or below in England, Wales and Northern Ireland, according to the Food Standards Agency.[13]

IN PRACTICE Probe the food, not the display, and record readings on the cold-chain quarantine record. For stores in Scotland, check Food Standards Scotland guidance.

REGIONAL NOTE · UNITED STATES

The FDA Food Code is a model code that state and local jurisdictions adopt. The 2022 edition requires time/temperature control for safety food to be cold-held at 5°C (41°F) or less.[14]

IN PRACTICE Check the version your state or county has adopted; editions and local amendments differ. Keep probe records with the time each reading was taken.

REGIONAL NOTE · EUROPEAN UNION

Regulation (EC) No 852/2004, Annex II, Chapter IX: foods that can support pathogens must not be kept at temperatures that risk health, and the cold chain is not to be interrupted, with limited periods allowed for handling.[15]

IN PRACTICE Use the limits in your national rules and your own food safety procedures as the trigger for taking stock off sale, and record each decision with the reading behind it.

REGIONAL NOTE · MIDDLE EAST (UAE)

The Dubai Municipality Food Code says high-risk food should be kept at or below 5°C, or at or above 60°C, and calls 5°C to 60°C the temperature danger zone.[16] Other emirates and GCC states set their own rules.

IN PRACTICE Confirm the authority and limits for each emirate or country you trade in, and brief night managers, who often find the alarm first.

A summary for orientation, not legal advice. Requirements depend on sector, size, licence and jurisdiction, and change over time. Confirm the current text with your legal and compliance teams.

DECISION RIGHTS

Who closes a store, who goes to cash, who speaks to the media

Name each owner and a deputy before peak. If the owner cannot be reached in ten minutes, the deputy decides.

DECISION	WHO DECIDES	WHO CAN ACT FIRST	WHO MUST BE TOLD
Close a store or pause entry	Store manager for safety; regional manager for trading.	The most senior colleague on the floor.	Regional manager, then the incident lead.
Switch to cash only	Incident lead for the estate; store manager for one store.	Store manager, using the cash procedure.	Regional manager and cash office.
Take systems offline	Incident lead, on IT and security advice.	IT security, only to stop an active attack.	Every store, with what it means for them.
Speak to the media	Communications lead, with the incident lead.	Nobody else. Stores use the holding line.	Regional managers and stores.
Evacuate or lock down	Store manager, or police on arrival.	Any colleague facing an immediate threat.	Regional manager, loss prevention.
Take chilled stock off sale	Store manager, on probe readings.	Any trained colleague.	Facilities and food safety.
Notify regulators, acquirers and insurers	Incident lead, with legal and the data protection lead.	Nobody until it is logged with reasons.	Executive team. Some deadlines run from awareness.

PART 02

Incident scenarios.

How a multi-store incident unfolds across stores, regions and head office, the first hour on the busiest day, and three scenarios to rehearse.

01 A retail severity ladder

02 The first hour of a peak outage

03 Across stores, region and head office

04 Three scenarios

05 Tracking what is still outstanding

06 The store status log

SEVERITY

A retail severity ladder that stores and head office share

Grade early and regrade often. If in doubt, go one level higher and step down later.

SEV 1 **Critical**	TRIGGERS Payments, tills or core systems down across many stores or online. A weapon, terror or life-safety incident at any store. Controller tampering at several sites.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Crisis team, all affected store and regional managers, IT and security leads, communications and legal. `Voice · SMS · push · bridge in 15 min`
SEV 2 **Major**	TRIGGERS Outage in one region or one channel. Serious assault on a colleague. Fridge or freezer failure with stock at risk. A credible threat to a store.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Incident manager, area and regional managers, IT or facilities on call, communications on standby. `SMS · push · escalate after 10 min`
SEV 3 **Moderate**	TRIGGERS Problem at a single store: tills failing, a violent incident without injury, one fridge alarm, an evacuation for a false alarm.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Store manager, area manager, service desk or facilities helpdesk. `Push · email`
SEV 4 **Minor**	TRIGGERS Verbal abuse logged, a single device fault, a near miss or a suspicious approach to staff.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Store manager, recorded for trend reporting and weekly review. `App · email`

THE FIRST HOUR

Peak Saturday, 07:40: card payments fail

An illustrative timeline. The cause is not yet known. Act on what you can see, name who decides at each step and watch for the stores that go quiet.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**First reports reach the service desk** Dozens of stores report card terminals declining. Online checkout errors climb.	SERVICE DESK
T+00:05	**Incident declared at SEV 1** Several regions and online are hit. The bridge opens and the decision log starts.	INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:10	**First instruction to every store** Go to the cash and offline procedure, stop restarting terminals, acknowledge. Stores silent after ten minutes go to their regional manager. Next update 08:30.	RETAIL OPERATIONS
T+00:15	**Find the cause, keep the evidence** Check provider status and internal systems for intrusion. Nothing is switched off without a decision.	SECURITY LEAD
T+00:20	**Protect people, tell customers** Managers may pause entry if queues become unsafe. Banner, social posts and store announcement: open, cash accepted, next update time.	SECURITY · COMMS
T+00:45	**Decide on containment** If attack is suspected: isolate, call the response provider, insurer and acquirer, and log when you became aware of any personal data breach.	SECURITY LEAD · LEGAL
T+01:00	**First update to the crisis team** Stores affected, cash position, customer impact, likely duration, decisions needed, next update.	INCIDENT MANAGER

MULTI-STORE SCENARIO

A peak-day outage across stores, region and head office

The same illustrative outage, seen lane by lane. Red marks where it usually goes wrong, navy marks who decides, and pale blue marks how progress is watched.

	07:40	07:50	08:00	08:30	09:30	11:00
Affected stores	Cards declined at tills in many stores	! Managers keep restarting terminals; queues build	Stores acknowledge and start the cash procedure	! Cash floats run low in busy stores	Each store confirms cards work again	Cash banked, losses and incidents logged
Regional managers		Alerted by app and SMS; acknowledge	Silent stores chased after ten minutes	◆ Closes two stores with unsafe queues	◆ Reopens stores once terminals are tested	Checks every store reopened and staffed
Head office incident lead		◆ Declares SEV 1 and opens the bridge	◆ Estate-wide switch to cash and offline	◆ Approves isolating systems on security advice	Store status board reviewed every 30 minutes	Stands down; open actions tracked to closure
IT and payments	Service desk sees failures in every region		Provider fault or attack? Evidence kept	! Pressure to restart before the cause is known	Payments restored region by region	Root cause and evidence passed to review
Communications		! Colleagues post online before any statement	Holding line and web banner live	◆ One spokesperson takes media calls	! Update runs late; stores fill the gap	Customer update and thanks to colleagues

Action · Decision · Where it goes wrong · Monitored

> Most failures sit between the lanes: a decision made at head office that nobody tells stores about, or a store problem that never reaches head office. Give each handover an owner and a time.

SCENARIOS

Three illustrative scenarios to rehearse before peak

GROCER, 400 STORES

Card terminals fail at 22:30 on a late-night trading evening in the last week of Ramadan

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

A provider outage hits two regions. Night managers wait for certainty and give customers different answers.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Acknowledgement per store, chased at ten minutes, and a status board reviewed every 30 minutes.

WHO DECIDES

The head office incident lead calls the estate-wide cash switch; regional managers close unsafe stores.

REHEARSE

Run one store on cash only for 30 minutes, on a night shift.

CONVENIENCE CHAIN, FRANCHISE AND COMPANY STORES

Freezers defrost overnight in a dozen stores

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Opening staff reset controllers and restock before anyone cuts the remote access they share.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

A quarantine record per store and a site list of controllers, ticked off as each is checked.

WHO DECIDES

Store managers take stock off sale; the head office lead orders controllers offline at every site.

REHEARSE

Ask area managers to name their controller models.

FASHION RETAILER, FLAGSHIP STORE

An aggressive group, then a call to lock down

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

A tannoy nobody hears upstairs, and no list of who is on shift or who locks which door.

HOW IT IS MONITORED

Each floor confirms it is secure and every colleague is accounted for against the shift list.

WHO DECIDES

The store manager locks down without waiting; police take over on arrival; head office supports.

REHEARSE

A ten-minute lockdown walk-through each quarter.

OUTSTANDING ACTIONS

Saturday 11:00: what is still open

An illustrative actions board three hours in. Every action has one owner, a due time and a way of checking it is done. Review it at every update until it is empty.

ACTION	OWNER	DUE	STATUS	HOW IT IS CHECKED
Confirm every store is taking cards again	Regional managers	11:30	IN PROGRESS	Store status board, store by store
Reopen the two stores closed for queue safety	Regional manager	12:00	OPEN	Terminals tested; reopening logged
Collect cash from stores over their float limit	Cash office	13:00	OPEN	Collection booked and confirmed
Customer FAQ and social media update	Communications	10:45	OVERDUE	Escalated to the incident lead at due time
Root cause statement from the payment provider	IT lead	17:00	BLOCKED	Chased at every update; waiting on provider
Reconcile offline and failed card transactions	Finance and IT	Sun 10:00	IN PROGRESS	Matched against the provider report
Aftercare for the colleague pushed in a queue	Loss prevention	Today	DONE	Call logged; incident report filed
Decide whether to notify regulators, the acquirer and the insurer	Incident lead, legal	Sun 12:00	OPEN	Decision, reasons and awareness time in the log
Book the post-incident review	Incident lead	Mon	DONE	Invite sent with the review template

> Overdue and blocked actions are raised at the next update, not left on the board. The incident lead decides whether to chase, reassign or escalate, and the decision goes in the log. The board closes only when every action is done or handed to the post-incident review.

STORE STATUS LOG

Store status log: one line per store, every update

Regional managers keep this for their stores during a multi-store incident, or head office keeps it for the estate. It shows at a glance who has heard, who is trading and who needs help.

STORE	ALERTED	ACKNOWLEDGED	TRADING STATUS	SAFETY OR QUEUE ISSUE	STOCK AT RISK	NEXT CHECK	INITIALS
Store 0147, North	*07:52*	*07:58, manager*	*Open, cash only*	*Long queue, entry paused 08:20*	*None*	*08:30*	*RM*

Trading status: open, cash only, closed for safety, closed for trading. A store with no acknowledgement after ten minutes is chased and marked in red at the next update.

PART 03

Respond and recover.

Procedures for violence, lockdown and a cold chain you cannot trust, the checks to finish before every peak and a dated plan with owners.

01 After an assault on a colleague

02 Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

03 A cold-chain incident

04 The cold-chain quarantine record

05 Peak readiness in six steps

06 This week, this month, this quarter

VIOLENCE AND ABUSE

After an assault on a colleague: six steps that matter

Abuse is a daily reality on shop floors everywhere. **United Kingdom:** the BRC estimates over 1,600 incidents of violence and abuse against retail staff a day, 118 of them physically violent.[6]

01 Make safe and get help

Call emergency services if anyone is hurt or in danger. Do not detain or follow the offender.

02 Look after the colleague

First aid, a quiet room, someone with them, a safe way home. Not back on the till.

03 Keep the evidence

Secure CCTV and body-worn video, note witnesses, write it up within the shift.

04 Report it, every time

Report to police and keep the reference. Every report builds the evidence for local policing and store risk reviews.

05 Tell head office within the hour

One message, one channel: area manager, security and HR hear the same facts.

06 Follow up and learn

Call the colleague next day, review staffing and layout, share intelligence locally.

PROTECTIVE PROCEDURES

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

Four procedures every large store needs, wherever it trades. Brief them, walk them through, and agree who decides on each.

Evacuation

Getting people away from danger by moving them out of the premises. Know your exits, assembly points and who sweeps each area.

Invacuation

Moving people to a safer place inside, such as a stockroom or back corridor away from glass and entrances.

Lockdown

Securing the premises to stop people entering or leaving. Know which doors lock, who locks them and how fast.

Communication

Getting information to everyone on site: colleagues, customers and contractors, with a way to reach staff who are off the shop floor.

United Kingdom: Martyn's Law will require shops where 200 or more people can be expected at once to have these four procedures; the duties are not yet in force.[17] **United States:** where an OSHA standard requires an emergency action plan, 29 CFR 1910.38 sets minimum elements, including reporting and evacuation procedures, accounting for employees and an alarm system.[18]

COLD CHAIN

When you cannot trust the fridge

Refrigeration controllers were tampered with remotely across Europe in autumn 2026. Treat an unexplained defrost as a possible attack until you know otherwise.

Spot it

An alarm, a case warming for no reason or a defrost cycle outside its schedule.

Check the food, not the display

Probe product temperatures by hand and compare them with the legal limit where you trade (see the regional notes in Part 01).

Take it off sale

Remove anything you cannot show stayed at a safe temperature. Record what, where and when for the insurer and food safety team.

Cut the remote link

With the contractor, take controllers off the internet and allow access only through a secure VPN. CERT-FR warns a factory reset alone is not enough for end-of-life kit.[4]

Restore and check every site

Reconfigure, check defrost schedules, then look for the same controllers at every other store and depot.

Check your insurance conditions before cutting data links to the refrigeration contractor, as CERT-FR advises.[4]

COLD-CHAIN RECORD

Cold-chain quarantine record

Fill one line for every case or unit you check after an unexplained defrost or alarm, against the limit that applies where you trade: for example 8°C in England, Wales and Northern Ireland, or 5°C (41°F) under the US FDA Food Code model. The record supports the insurer, the food safety team and the review.

CASE OR UNIT	PRODUCT OR SECTION	PROBE READING AND TIME	DISPLAY READING	ACTION TAKEN	QUANTITY AND VALUE	CHECKED BY
Freezer 3, aisle 9	*Frozen desserts*	*-4°C at 06:15*	*-18°C*	*Off sale, held for insurer*	*42 units*	*Duty manager*

Probe the food, not the display: the display reading comes from the controller you may not be able to trust. Do not reset the controller or restock until remote access has been cut and the contractor has checked it.

BEFORE EVERY PEAK

Peak readiness in six steps

Finish these before every peak: Black Friday (White Friday in the Gulf),[19] Christmas, Ramadan and Eid. In Ramadan 2024, Visa found late-night transactions doubled their share in Saudi Arabia, to 35%.[20]

01 Freeze change and name the on-call team

No non-essential changes to payments, tills, e-commerce or networks. Publish who is on call, day and night.

02 Test the offline and cash procedure

Confirm what each till and terminal can do offline, how much cash float stores hold and who decides to go cash only.

03 Rehearse one outage and one lockdown

A 30-minute exercise with store and regional managers: a payment failure at the busiest hour, then a lockdown call.

04 Check every contact list

Managers, suppliers, payment providers, acquirers and contractors, each with a tested out-of-hours number.

05 Close the doors you forgot

List fridge controllers, building systems and supplier remote access that face the internet, and take them off it.[4,5]

06 Brief colleagues on safety

De-escalation, raising an alarm, when not to intervene and who to call.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure, and date every action.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Publish the peak on-call rota and change freeze. Send the severity ladder and the message templates to every store.	Head of resilience
This week	Test the cash and offline procedure in one store per region. Confirm payment provider and acquirer escalation contacts.	Retail operations director
This month	Take fridge controllers and other building systems off the internet. Review supplier remote access.	Facilities and IT security
This month	Build a notification map: for each country, the data protection regulator, deadline, card acquirer and food authority.	Data protection lead, with legal
This quarter	Check protective security duties by country, such as Martyn's Law in the UK and emergency action plans in the US, and draft the four procedures per format.	Head of security, with legal
This quarter	Run a joint store, region and head office exercise on a cyber outage. Report gaps and dated fixes to the board.	Chief operating officer

PRACTICAL TOOLKIT

Seven tools for your next incident

The same seven tools appear in every Crises Control playbook, with examples for your industry. Copy them, adapt them and rehearse with them.

01 **Readiness assessment** 28
Score eight areas from 0 to 3 and find your weakest link.

02 **Roles and responsibilities matrix** 29
Who is responsible, accountable, consulted and informed for each activity.

03 **Incident decision log** 30
Record every material decision, who made it and why, as it happens.

04 **Escalation workflow** 31
Four levels, their triggers, who is alerted and who decides.

05 **Communication templates** 32
Ready-to-send messages for staff, customers, regulators, partners and media.

06 **Tabletop exercise** 33
A ready-to-run scenario with timed injects and questions for the room.

07 **Post-incident review template** 34
Eight prompts that turn an incident into lessons and owned actions.

> Every tool works on paper. In Crises Control the same roles, escalation rules, templates and logs can be set up in the platform, so they run during the incident and leave a record afterwards.

TOOLKIT 01 · READINESS ASSESSMENT

How ready is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your retail organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 · ACTIVATION **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Every store manager and on-call colleague reached in minutes, on more than one channel.	0 1 2 3
02 · ACTIVATION **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation by rule? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Store-by-store acknowledgement, with escalation when a store stays silent.	0 1 2 3
03 · COORDINATION **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Escalation from store to region to head office runs by rule.	0 1 2 3
04 · COORDINATION **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by IT, store operations, loss prevention and communications.	0 1 2 3
05 · EXECUTION **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Fallback, lockdown and cold-chain procedures run as owned tasks in every store.	0 1 2 3
06 · EXECUTION **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Head office sees which stores are trading, closed or at risk, live.	0 1 2 3
07 · ASSURANCE **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline for insurers, the ICO or a post-incident review, ready the next day.	0 1 2 3
08 · ASSURANCE **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Peak-trading scenarios rehearsed with stores, not only at head office.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

TOOLKIT 02 · ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES MATRIX

Who does what: store, region and head office

A suggested matrix for a multi-store incident. Agree it before peak and adjust it to your structure.

ACTIVITY	STORE MANAGER	REGIONAL MANAGER	HEAD OFFICE INCIDENT LEAD	IT AND SECURITY	COMMS	LOSS PREVENTION
Raise the first report	A	I	I	I	·	I
Declare and set the severity	C	C	A	C	I	I
Switch to cash and offline	R	R	A	C	I	I
Close one store for safety	A	I	I	·	I	C
Close stores across a region	R	A	C	·	I	I
Contain systems, keep evidence	I	I	A	R	·	C
Chase silent stores	R	A	I	·	·	·
Customer and media statements	I	I	C	C	A	I
Colleague safety and lockdown	A	C	I	·	I	R
Keep CCTV, report to police	R	I	I	·	·	A
Reopen and return to normal	R	R	A	C	I	I

R Responsible: does the work A Accountable: owns the decision C Consulted I Informed

> One rule overrides the matrix: a store manager never needs permission to act on safety. Closing a door, pausing entry or calling emergency services is theirs to decide; head office is told straight after.

TOOLKIT 03 · INCIDENT DECISION LOG

Every call that closes a store, switches to cash or takes a system offline

Use it from the moment the incident is declared. In a retail incident it also records when you became aware of any personal data breach, which starts notification deadlines in several jurisdictions.

TIME	DECISION	OPTIONS CONSIDERED	DECIDED BY	RATIONALE	EVIDENCE OR REFERENCE
08:05	*Switch every store to the cash and offline procedure*	*Wait for the provider; switch affected regions only; switch the whole estate*	*Head office incident lead*	*Failures in every region; no fix time from provider; queues building*	*Store status log; provider status page*

Log decisions as they are made, not afterwards. Include decisions not to act. The log is the backbone of the timeline your board, auditors and regulators will ask for.

TOOLKIT 04 · ESCALATION WORKFLOW

Escalating from store to region to head office

Four levels that match the severity ladder. The times are suggested starting points; set your own and write them into your alerting rules, so escalation does not depend on someone remembering.

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 1 **Store**	One store: tills failing, an aggressive customer, a single fridge alarm, a false fire alarm.	Store manager, colleagues on shift, the service desk or facilities helpdesk.	Store manager: pause entry, go cash only, take stock off sale, call emergency services.

↓ ESCALATE IF TWO OR MORE STORES ARE HIT, ANYONE IS HURT, OR THERE IS NO FIX IN 30 MINUTES

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 2 **Region**	The same fault in several stores in one region, a serious assault, stock at risk or a credible threat.	Regional manager, area managers, IT or facilities on call, loss prevention.	Regional manager: close stores in the region, move colleagues, ask head office for support.

↓ ESCALATE IF MORE THAN ONE REGION OR ONLINE IS HIT, OR ANY STORE IS SILENT AFTER 10 MINUTES

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 3 **Head office**	Payments, tills or core systems down across regions or online, a suspected cyber attack, a lockdown or life-safety incident.	Head office incident lead, IT and security, communications, loss prevention, every affected regional manager.	Head office incident lead: estate-wide cash procedure, systems offline, customer messages.

↓ ESCALATE IF TRADING CANNOT RESUME BY THE NEXT UPDATE, OR DATA OR MEDIA ARE INVOLVED

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 4 **Executive crisis team**	Business-wide disruption, a data breach, serious injury or death, sustained media attention.	Executive team, legal, communications director, insurer and incident response provider.	Executive lead: closing the estate or online, public statements, regulator, acquirer and insurer notifications.

> Silence is a signal. A store that has not acknowledged within ten minutes is chased by its regional manager; a regional manager who has not acknowledged is replaced by their deputy and the head office incident lead is told.

TOOLKIT 05 · COMMUNICATION TEMPLATES

Six messages ready to send

Short, specific and honest. Fill the brackets, never guess the cause, and always give the time of the next update.

SMS · STORE MANAGERS

146 chars

> SEV1: Card payments down in many stores. Switch to cash and offline procedure now. Do not restart terminals. Reply 1 when done. Next update 08:30.

Keep it under 160 characters so it arrives as one message.

PUSH · ALL STORE COLLEAGUES

> Some payment systems are down. Your safety comes first. Stay calm, use the till script, call security if anyone becomes aggressive. Please do not post about this online.

WEB BANNER · CUSTOMERS

> We're sorry: some card payments aren't working in our stores right now. Stores are open and accepting [cash]. We're working to fix it and will update here at [10:00].

Only say what you know is true. Add what still works.

EMAIL · DATA PROTECTION REGULATOR

> Initial notice of a personal data breach. Controller: [name, ref]. Became aware: [date, time]. What happened: [summary]. Data and people affected: [types, approx. numbers]. Measures taken: [summary]. Contact: [lead]. More to follow by [date].

Use the regulator's own form where there is one. Send what you know now and the rest in phases.

EMAIL · SUPPLIERS AND HAULIERS

> We are managing an IT incident affecting [systems]. Deliveries continue as booked unless we call you. Do not act on any request to change bank details or give access. Verify on [known number].

Attackers often follow up with fake supplier requests.

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA

> We are aware of an issue affecting payments in some of our stores and are working to resolve it as quickly as possible. Our stores remain open. We will share more information as soon as we can.

TOOLKIT 06 · TABLETOP EXERCISE

Exercise: tills down on the busiest Saturday of peak

An illustrative 90-minute exercise for store, regional and head office leads. Read each inject aloud, give the room five minutes, and record every decision, owner and gap.

DURATION	PARTICIPANTS	OBJECTIVE	FACILITATOR
90 minutes, six injects	Store and regional managers, head office lead, IT, comms, loss prevention	Test decision rights and store acknowledgement across many stores	Head of resilience or an external facilitator

09:55	INJECT 1 Card payments fail in 120 stores across three regions. Online checkout is slow.	DISCUSS Who declares, at what level? What is the first instruction to stores, and by when?
10:10	INJECT 2 Eighteen stores have not acknowledged. Two regional managers are on leave.	DISCUSS How do you know who is silent? Who covers for the absent regional managers?
10:30	INJECT 3 A queue in a large store turns hostile and a colleague is pushed.	DISCUSS Who decides to pause entry or close? What support does the colleague get, and who checks?
10:50	INJECT 4 IT finds signs of intrusion and wants to take the store network offline.	DISCUSS Who approves? What will stores lose, who tells them, and when does a notification clock start?
11:15	INJECT 5 A journalist calls a store directly. A video of the queue is spreading online.	DISCUSS Who speaks for the business? What does the store say, word for word?
13:00	INJECT 6 Freezer alarms in six stores. They share the same controller model.	DISCUSS Is it connected? Who decides on stock, and who checks every other site?

> Afterwards, score yourselves on the Readiness assessment, put every gap on the outstanding actions board with an owner and a date, and run the exercise again before the next peak.

TOOLKIT 07 · POST-INCIDENT REVIEW TEMPLATE

Post-incident review for a multi-store incident

Hold the review within two weeks, with stores in the room as well as head office. Look for causes, not culprits, and turn every finding into a dated action.

INCIDENT	DATE	SEVERITY	REVIEW LEAD

01 What happened

A timeline from the first store report to stand down, built from the Incident decision log, not from memory.

02 Detection and first report

How was it first spotted in store? How long until head office knew, and how?

03 Alerting and acknowledgement

Which stores acknowledged, and how fast? Who stayed silent, and why?

04 Decisions and decision rights

Who decided to close stores, go to cash or take systems offline? Were they the right people?

05 Stores and colleagues

Trading lost, stores closed, colleagues hurt or abused, aftercare given and still needed.

06 Customers, regulators and suppliers

What was said, when and by whom? Were notification deadlines met, and did stores know first?

07 What worked and what did not

Procedures, tools, contact lists and handovers between store, region and head office.

08 Actions, owners and dates

Every finding becomes an action with one owner and a due date, tracked to closure and reported.

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

TRADING

? If every card terminal failed at our busiest hour, how long until every store had one clear instruction?

? Which head office shutdown decisions would stop stores trading, and who tells them?

? Do we know which store systems and fridge controllers face the internet today?

PEOPLE AND DUTIES

? Is every assault on a colleague reported, followed up and visible to the board?

? Could each large store evacuate, invacuate or lock down today, and has it practised?

? Do we know who we must notify after a data breach in each country, and how fast?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready for peak?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **One severity ladder used by stores and head office**
  With named owners for each level.

- [ ] **Peak on-call rota and change freeze published**
  Covering every trading day and night of each peak.

- [ ] **Cash and offline procedure tested before peak**
  In at least one store per region.

- [ ] **Message templates approved and loaded**
  Store managers, colleagues, customers, regulators, suppliers and media.

- [ ] **Fridge controllers and building systems off the internet**
  Remote access only through a secure route.

- [ ] **Notification map ready for every country**
  Regulator, deadline, acquirer and food authority, with a named owner.

- [ ] **Evacuation, invacuation and lockdown briefed**
  And walked through in large stores.

- [ ] **Every store acknowledges alerts**
  And non-responders are chased under escalation rules you set.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Severity level
A shared grade (SEV 1 to SEV 4) that sets who is alerted, how fast and how often.

Offline payment mode
A terminal setting that stores some card transactions for later authorisation when the network is down.

Acquirer
The bank or provider that processes card payments for a retailer and receives incident reports about card data.

Change freeze
A period, usually over peak, when only essential changes to systems are allowed.

Supervisory authority
The data protection regulator that receives breach notifications, for example the Information Commission in the UK.

Invacuation
Moving people to a safer place inside a building, away from danger outside.

Lockdown
Securing a building so people cannot enter or leave until it is safe.

Martyn's Law (UK)
The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, which sets duties for larger public premises in the UK.

Cold chain
Keeping chilled and frozen food at safe temperatures from supplier to shelf.

Refrigeration controller
A device that runs fridges and freezers and can often be managed remotely.

Defrost cycle
A scheduled warm-up that clears ice. Stretched or repeated, it spoils stock.

Acknowledgement
A recipient's confirmation that an alert has been read and acted on.

Incident manager
The person who runs the response, keeps the log and sets the rhythm of updates.

Holding line
A short, accurate statement used while facts are still being established.

White Friday
The name used for Black Friday sales in much of the Gulf.

End of life
When a manufacturer stops issuing security fixes for a product.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end.

When card payments fail on Black Friday, a message to stores is minute one. Trading through it depends on which stores acknowledged, who switched to the fallback, what customers were told, and an accurate picture for head office.

WHERE INCIDENTS GO WRONG

01	**Fragmented information**	Different teams work from different information.
02	**Delayed decision making**	Leadership lacks visibility, so decisions wait.
03	**Uncoordinated response**	Several teams work independently on the same problem.
04	**Lack of visibility**	Critical actions become difficult to track.
05	**Lack of accountability**	Actions and decisions are poorly documented.

THE WHOLE INCIDENT, IN ONE PLATFORM



Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. It helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform.

THE PLATFORM

One connected platform, from first alert to final report.

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end. Crises Control helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform. Each module of this incident management software does one job; the value comes from how they work together across the incident.

01

ESCALATE

SOS

Frontline staff raise an alert from the mobile app, with location where available.

02

START

Ping

Alerting and activation: reach people and collect acknowledgements and responses.

03

COORDINATE

Incident Manager

Authorised users activate the incident and its response plan, assign roles, control communication and keep the timeline.

04

EXECUTE

Task Manager

Assign actions, track completion and escalate what stalls, with clear accountability.

05

OPERATE

Control Centre

Real-time view of incidents, timelines, task status and assets.

06

PROVE

Audit & Reporting

Incident records, response analysis and task accountability, ready to report.

07

ASSIST

CRAiG

AI assistant (beta) that answers questions and summarises incident data. People make every decision.

THE OUTCOMES

Alerting and activation

Reach the right people immediately.

Operational coordination

Structure communication and response activities.

Execution and visibility

Track tasks, responsibilities and progress.

Proof and accountability

Create a complete, defensible operational record.

Most organisations start with the capability they need today, often alerting, and expand as their requirements mature. Highlighted modules are the ones this playbook draws on.

HOW THE MODULES WORK TOGETHER

Crises Control, an Operational Incident Coordination Platform, in a retail incident

The peak-day outage from this playbook, step by step, from the first store report to the record for insurers, regulators and the review. Plans, groups and escalation rules are the ones your team configures.

01	ESCALATE **SOS**	A store manager raises the incident from the app or web; a colleague at risk on the shop floor uses SOS, sharing location where available.
02	START **Ping**	Store and regional managers receive the cash procedure by push, SMS and voice and acknowledge in one tap; silent stores escalate to their regional manager under rules you configure.
03	COORDINATE **Incident Manager**	Head office launches the response plan, assigns store, regional and head office roles and keeps one communication log.
04	EXECUTE **Task Manager**	The cash procedure, queue safety and reopening checks become owned tasks with deadlines in every store, from the plan you built.
05	OPERATE **Control Centre**	Head office and regional managers see who has acknowledged, the responses each store has chosen and task progress, live.
06	PROVE **Audit & Reporting**	A timestamped record of messages, acknowledgements, decisions logged and tasks exports as PDF or CSV for insurers, regulators and the review.
07	ASSIST **CRAiG**	CRAiG (beta) answers questions such as which stores have not acknowledged, using the incident data each user is permitted to see.

COORDINATION
Everyone works from the same incident, roles and log.

VISIBILITY
Leaders see progress without chasing for updates.

EXECUTION
Every action has an owner, a deadline and an escalation.

ACCOUNTABILITY
The record of what happened builds itself as you go.

WHAT IS STANDARD, WHAT IS CONFIGURED

Clear about what the platform does.

Some capabilities work as standard. Others depend on how your team sets up plans, groups and rules, or on connecting your own systems. Your demonstration and implementation plan confirm what applies to you.

STANDARD

Included in how each module works.

- SOS press-and-hold alert from the mobile app, raising an incident and sharing location where available
- Ping alerts by push, SMS, voice, email and desktop, with one-tap acknowledgement
- Incident Manager workspace, roles and a single communication log
- Task Manager tasks with owners and deadlines when a plan is activated
- Control Centre live view of status, acknowledgements, tasks and locations
- Audit & Reporting: timestamped records, exportable as PDF or CSV
- CRAiG (beta): answers questions and summarises your incident data within each user's permissions

CONFIGURED

Set up by your team to match your plans.

- Response plans, task lists and message templates per incident type
- Groups, sites and audiences to target
- Escalation rules and timings when people do not respond
- Cascading from one channel to the next
- Response options people can choose when they acknowledge

INTEGRATIONS

Connected to your other systems, where configured.

- Directory sync with Microsoft Entra ID, SCIM or scheduled file import
- Single sign-on with Entra ID, Google Workspace or Okta
- The Microsoft Teams app, enabled by your administrator
- Triggers from monitoring or other systems, set up as an integration project

> Crises Control does not detect incidents on its own. Incidents are raised by people, through SOS, the app or the web, or by connected systems where an integration has been configured. From that point the platform coordinates the response.

USE CASES

How organisations use Crises Control in retail

From the first alert to the final record: the incidents this platform is used for, and how the modules work together in each.

Store emergencies and evacuations

ILLUSTRATIVE

TRIGGER Fire, security threat, violence, severe weather or another store emergency

Alert store employees and managers, provide instructions, track acknowledgements and coordinate response and reopening tasks.

Ping | Incident Manager | Task Manager | Control Centre | SOS | Audit & Reporting

Cold-chain and refrigeration failures

ILLUSTRATIVE

TRIGGER Refrigeration or temperature monitoring indicates stock may be outside safe limits

Notify store and facilities teams, assign checks and corrective actions, escalate unresolved issues and record actions taken.

Ping | Incident Manager | Task Manager | Control Centre | Audit & Reporting

Multi-store incident coordination

ILLUSTRATIVE

TRIGGER A disruption affects multiple stores or regions

Notify affected stores and regional managers, share consistent instructions, coordinate local actions and give head office visibility of progress.

Ping | Incident Manager | Task Manager | Control Centre | Audit & Reporting

Business continuity and store reopening

ILLUSTRATIVE

TRIGGER A store must close, operate differently or reopen after an incident

Distribute store-specific continuity instructions, assign recovery and safety checks, confirm completion and communicate reopening decisions.

Ping | Incident Manager | Task Manager | Control Centre

Payment, IT and cybersecurity disruption

ILLUSTRATIVE

TRIGGER Payment terminals, point-of-sale systems, networks or applications become unavailable

Alert affected stores and support teams, communicate workarounds and updates, assign technical and operational actions, and monitor recovery.

Ping | Incident Manager | Task Manager | Control Centre | Audit & Reporting

Customer examples are based on how customers use Crises Control today; customer names have been removed. Customer requirements describe needs raised by customers or in evaluations. Intended, suggested and illustrative use cases show how the platform can be applied and are not presented as existing customer deployments. Capabilities marked 'where configured' or 'where supported' depend on each organisation's set-up.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is spotted and escalated, and what you must configure.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location where available, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

SOURCES

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BOOK YOUR RETAIL PLATFORM DEMONSTRATION

Watch a multi-store outage run end to end.

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end. In a live, 30-minute demonstration built around a retail incident, you will see how our incident management software, an Operational Incident Coordination Platform, takes one incident from first alert to final report. Bring your own scenario.

WHAT YOU WILL SEE

01	SOS	A store manager reports tills down, with location where available.
02	PING	Store managers and regional managers are alerted; each store acknowledges.
03	INCIDENT MANAGER	Head office activates the incident and assigns store, regional and head office roles.
04	TASK MANAGER	Fallback, customer messaging and cash procedures become tasks in every store.
05	CONTROL CENTRE	Head office sees which stores are trading, closed or at risk.
06	AUDIT & REPORTING	The incident timeline is produced for insurers and the review.
07	CRAIG	CRAiG helps head office find information and guidance in the platform.

Book your demonstration →

crises-control.com/retail-incident-management-software/

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SCAN TO BOOK

COMPANION REPORT When the tills go dark